

report. If you're only getting an inspection to check the major items—like the HVAC system, roof, structural integrity, and radon levels—make sure to note this in your offer and specify what needs to pass inspection. This contingency is especially helpful if you're buying an old, ugly home to force appreciation. You probably don't care if the ancient shag carpet has stains on it when you're planning on ripping it all out anyway.

- **Show that you can close.** All concessions aside, the easiest thing you can do to make your offer more competitive is to prove to the seller that you can close. If you've followed our advice so far—you're a pre-approved, well-qualified borrower with a stable job and a ready down payment—you're showing the seller that you're financially awesome.

By adding any of these options to your offer contract (as well as demonstrating that you can close), you're tempting the seller to choose you over anyone else. If you love the house and know it's a good deal, one of these buyer concessions could make all the difference between going under contract or starting again from scratch. Still, make sure you're willing and able to offer each of these before you actually do—for example, don't opt for an appraisal gap guarantee if you're unable to bring extra cash to the closing. You'll be contractually obligated to do so should that issue arise.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

- Your offer contract will dictate all the terms of the transaction, and it should be as specific as possible to avoid any confusion down the line. Your agent knows how to put it all together, but you should tell them to include anything that's important to you.
- There are about a million sections in your contract, but the most important are the purchase price, deadlines, inclusions and exclusions, and contingencies with which you can back out of the contract. Okay, we don't mean to pick favorites—*all* of them are important, but you should keep a special eye on these four.